During the Second World War, a certain amount of road building had begun in the Lohit and Subansiri divisions of NEFA as part of the attempt to administer the area right up to the claimed border as per the Simla Agreement of 1914. However, Tawang and the entire Kameng Division had been left strictly alone after having established the British-Indian claim on Tawang in 1938 by sending the Gordon Lightfoot Expedition to plant the flag.

After 1914, the only known ingress by the Tibetans into Indian territory was in 1942 when they occupied the Tawang salient and the area south of Se-la extending down to the plains near Udalguri. At this time, the British government was fully preoccupied with the Japanese in Kohima and Imphal and, as a result, had ignored Lhasa's incursion. At that point, the British and American governments had been following a policy of appeasement to keep the leader of the Republic of China, Chiang Kai-shek, fighting on their side in World War II. As a result, the security of North Assam had been downgraded. However, once the situation stabilized and it became obvious that the British would defeat the Japanese, the Tibetans had quietly withdrawn. Interestingly, no diplomatic notes were exchanged about the incident—both sides preferring to behave as if the incident never happened.

Immediately after the war, Tibet officially continued to affirm its acceptance of the Simla Convention. In October 1944, Tibet's governing council, the Kashag, had officially written to the Indian government that it 'did not wish to dispute the validity of the McMahon Line', but had requested postponement of the extension of the British administration to Tawang. In 1947, Lhasa accepted the transfer of power in Delhi without any declared reservations. It also tacitly accepted independent India's legal position that as the natural inheritor of all treaties between Britain and Tibet, it would continue to abide by them.

By early 1951, political officers were reporting increased Chinese activity in various parts of NEFA. Most of the Assam Rifles posts were on the McMahon Line, with extended lines of communication running through areas with little or no administrative control. Accordingly, a few posts were set up in the interior to meet tactical requirements. Walong and Hayuliang were established with a platoon each under the command of an officer, while two checkposts were established in the upper reaches of the Siang Valley. However, the governor of Assam, Jairamdas Daulatram, under whose control the Assam Rifles functioned, was most concerned about the